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Top 15 Communication Idioms To Use At Work

Ever feel like your colleagues **speak in riddles**? It's true that native-English speakers sometimes talk **a mile a minute**, but knowing all these communication idioms will help you keep up with them!

Communication Idioms

Here you have a list with the most common idioms about communication. Check it out and [put them in practice](#) at work or with a teacher:

He talks a mile a minute .	- Very quickly.
If you ever come to New York, drop me a line .	- Send me a note or a letter.
Tell me about it, get it off your chest .	- Say it and feel relieved.
"Are you listening to me?" "Yes, I'm all ears ."	- I'm paying attention to you.
Please keep me In the loop / He said we kept him out of the loop ,	- Aware (or unaware) of information known to only a group.
I've tried to discuss it with her, but it's like talking to a brick wall .	- The person is not listening or paying attention.
It's on the tip of my tongue .	- I can almost remember but not quite.
Anyway, long story short , we're moving to Germany.	- To skip boring, unnecessary details.
"How much is the house worth?" " Off the top of my head , I'd say around \$160,000."	- From memory, without thinking too much.

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They put me on the spot when they asked me about my other projects.	- They forced me into a difficult situation / asked me a difficult question.
Rumors spread like wildfire when people are excited.	- Circulate very quickly.
Take everything she says with a pinch of salt , because she tends to exaggerate.	- Be a bit skeptical about it.
Stop talking in riddles and tell me what this is about.	- Speak in a convoluted/complicated way.
I was just calling to touch base since it's been a few weeks since we last spoke.	- To contact someone for an update.
We get most of our work through word-of-mouth recommendations.	- Spread by people talking about it.

Conversation questions

- Do you know anyone who **speaks in riddles**?
- What is something you found out through **word of mouth**?
- From your friends, do you have to take any of them **with a pinch of salt**?
- What do you do when you have something **on the tip of your tongue**?
- Have you ever tried to discuss something with someone and it was **like talking to a brick wall**?
- What do you do if a colleague/customer is talking **a mile a minute** and you can't understand?
- **Off the top of your head**, how many employees are there in your company?
- Have you ever felt that you needed to **get something off your chest**?
- Have any rumors about you ever **spread like wildfire**?

Exercise

Fill the gaps with the correct word:

1. I can't really understand my new colleague. He talks a __ a minute.
2. We've tried to make him understand, but it's like talking to a __ wall.
3. Sorry I told you this long story, I just needed to get it off my __.
4. If you ever need anything, drop me a __.
5. Her name? Oh, it's on the __ of my tongue.
6. Tell me about your new project, I'm all __.
7. We'll keep you in the __ with all the updates.
8. Anyway, __ story short, we need to postpone the deadline.
9. He's very hard-working, but when it comes to timeline, take him with a __ of salt.
10. She explained the whole thing, but to be honest, she was talking in __ and no one fully understood.
11. Hi, I was just calling to touch __. How's the new venture going?
12. How did you find out about them? Just word of __!

Solutions:

1. I can't really understand my new colleague. He talks a **mile** a minute.
2. We've tried to make him understand, but it's like talking to a **brick** wall.
3. Sorry I told you this long story, I just needed to get it off my **chest**.
4. If you ever need anything, drop me a **line**.
5. Her name? Oh, it's on the **tip** of my tongue.
6. Tell me about your new project, I'm all **ears**.
7. We'll keep you in the **loop** with all the updates.
8. Anyway, **long** story short, we need to postpone the deadline.
9. He's very hard-working, but when it comes to timeline, take him with a **pinch** of salt.
10. She explained the whole thing, but to be honest, she was talking in **riddles** and no one fully understood.
11. Hi, I was just calling to touch **base**. How's the new venture going?
12. How did you find out about them? Just word of **mouth**!



30 Must-Know Idioms About Negotiations & Agreements

Negotiations are not easy, but they're even harder if you're not a native speaker. . And because knowing common expressions will help you get the **upper hand**, here you have a list with the 30 must-know idioms about negotiations and agreements that you can start using today at work.

Negotiations & Agreements Idioms

Here you have a list with the most common idioms about negotiations and disagreements. Check them out and [put them in practice](#) at work or with a teacher:

The speaker was just beating around the bush and never said anything important.	- Talk about something without giving a direct answer
We will bend over backwards if the other party is committed.	- Make every effort to achieve something, especially to be fair or helpful
After insisting for months, the manager caved in to his demands.	- Submit under pressure
You're the boss here – you get to call the shots .	- To be in the position of being able to make the decisions in a situation; to be the person who controls a situation
When I first met him I didn't like him but I've changed my mind .	- Change your decision
The salesman came in high during the negotiations and could not sell his product. / The company came in low with an offer for our product.	- Charge too much/too little for your services, to ask for a price that is too high/low

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The participants seem unable to find common ground on the issue of environment.	- Agree about something, share opinions or interests
The questions were endless and we were unable to cover much ground during the meeting.	- Talk about the important facts and details of something
The union was flexible on the salary issue but they drew the line at talking about health benefits.	- Set a limit on what one is willing to do or accept
Our boss said that wages would improve soon but he never followed through with his promise.	- To be consequent with what was agreed, to keep a promise
She got the short end of the stick in the deal.	- To be in a disadvantaged situation, to suffer the bad effects of something
My grandfather was such a hard-nosed businessman.	- To be tough, stubborn, or uncompromising
She has a card up her sleeve if they ever try to fire her, since she knows about all those secret business practices.	- Have a strategy kept secret and in reserve for use when needed
I kept looking over to see if she was impressed, but she wore a poker face throughout the presentation.	- A blank, emotionless expression that gives no indication of one's thoughts or intentions
After hours of fierce negotiations, the president got the upper hand .	- A position of advantage, power, and/or control
I know she really wants the promotion, but she really hit me below the belt by telling the boss about my personal problems.	- Unfairly target someone's weakness or vulnerability
Management holds all the cards when it comes to the negotiations over job cuts.	- To be in a position of power or control over someone or something else
The election is in the bag .	- Certain to be won, achieved, or obtained
You deserve honesty, so I'm going to lay my cards on the table : I can't offer you this job, but we may have another position	- To be frank and outspoken; to reveal something that you have kept hidden, such as your, intentions, opinion, etc.

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that you'd be good for.	
We had no contract; it was done by a gentleman's agreement .	- An arrangement or understanding which is based on the trust of both or all parties, rather than being legally binding
I'll agree to some of your requests if you'll meet me halfway and allow me to implement some of my ideas.	- Compromise with someone, often in an argument or disagreement
Many consumers are still on the fence , waiting for a less expensive computer to come along.	- Undecided; not able to make a decision
He's a nice guy, but he can play hardball when he needs to.	- To be firm and determined in order to get what you want
As a manager, you have to put your foot down sometimes, or your staff will walk all over you.	- Use your authority; be inflexible in your position or decision
(a) Why are you second-guessing me now? You agreed with this strategy just yesterday! / (b) He had to second-guess what the environmental regulations would be in five years' time.	- (a) Question or doubt someone or something retroactively. (b) Try to anticipate how something will happen or what someone will do
Why don't you sleep on the offer and let us know your decision in the morning?	- Postpone a decision until the following day so that one has additional time to consider it
I kept trying to get our boss to find a bigger office, but she stood her ground .	- Refuse to change your opinion or give in
I've done everything I could. The ball is in your court now.	- It's your turn to make a decision or take action
Andrea was about to play her trump card - without her signature none of the money could be released.	- A resource used to gain an advantage over others, often by being held and then used at an opportune time
Yes, we did have our disagreements but that's water under the bridge now.	- Problems that someone had in the past that they do not worry about because they happened a long time ago and cannot now be changed

Conversation questions

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- Do you tend to **second-guess** your decisions?
- When was the last time you needed to **sleep on** something before making a decision?
- Do you ever **play hardball** when you negotiate?
- Talk about a time when you were **on the fence** about something.
- Talk about a time when your manager **put his/her foot down**.
- Would you say you're a **hard-nosed** negotiator or you don't mind **meeting** the other person **halfway**?
- When did you feel that a negotiation or a deal was **in the bag**?
- Do you always **lay your cards on the table** or do you tend to **keep a card up your sleeve**?
- When was a time in which you didn't **follow through with** a promise?
- Have you ever felt that you **got the short end of the stick**?
- Did you **cover** much **ground** during your last meeting?
- Who **calls the shots** in your department?
- When was the last time you **caved in to** someone's demands?
- Do you feel you always **bend over backwards** at work?
- What do you do when a colleague starts **beating around the bush** during a meeting or a presentation?

Exercise

Fill the gaps with the correct word:

1. He said he was uncompromising, but after some pressure he __ in to our requests.
2. Listen, I want to lay all my __ on the table - we can't pay that much money but we can give you this package instead.
3. I always feel I'm bending over __ and get nothing in return.
4. You should talk to my manager about that, she's the one calling the __.
5. I thought it would be a smooth negotiation, but she was playing __.
6. It's a lot of money, let me __ on it and I'll tell you something tomorrow.
7. They accepted our offer too quickly, I feel we came in __.
8. He seemed like a nice guy, but we were unable to find common __ when we talked.
9. I'm very flexible on the deadline, but I have to draw the __ with the budget.
10. You promised to send me all the information, but you never followed __.
11. I know we need to make a decision, but I'm still on the __.
12. How are the negotiations going? - Well, it's not in the __ yet, but I think we've got the upper __.
13. I didn't expect it, but he played his __ card and now we're stuck.

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14. We didn't have the best start, but that's water under the __ now.
15. Please stop __ around the bush and get to the point.

Solutions:

1. He said he was uncompromising, but after some pressure he caved in to our requests.
2. Listen, I want to lay all my cards on the table - we can't pay that much money but we can give you this package instead.
3. I always feel I'm bending over backwards and get nothing in return.
4. You should talk to my manager about that, she's the one calling the shots.
5. I thought it would be a smooth negotiation, but she was playing hardball.
6. It's a lot of money, let me sleep on it and I'll tell you something tomorrow.
7. They accepted our offer too quickly, I feel we came in low.
8. He seemed like a nice guy, but we were unable to find common ground when we talked.
9. I'm very flexible on the deadline, but I have to draw the line with the budget.
10. You promised to send me all the information, but you never followed through.
11. I know we need to make a decision, but I'm still on the fence.
12. How are the negotiations going? - Well, it's not in the bag yet, but I think we've got the upper hand.
13. I didn't expect it, but he played his trump card and now we're stuck.
14. We didn't have the best start, but that's water under the bridge now.
15. Please stop beating around the bush and get to the point.



Problems at Work? Learn These 18 Idioms About Challenges

Being a non-native English speaker in such a competitive world can be tough sometimes, but you don't have to **roll with the punches**. Instead, you can improve your communication skills and put yourself on a par with native speakers. Learn these idioms and phrases to talk about challenges at work, and don't let the opportunity to shine at work **slip through your fingers**.

Challenges Idioms

Here you have a list with the most common idioms about challenges. Check them out and [put them in practice](#) at work or with a teacher:

They should go back to the drawing board and review the whole issue of employee training.	- Start over and go back to the beginning or the planning stage
I hate doing these reports, but I'll just have to bite the bullet .	- Do something unpleasant that needs to be done
Losing to a smaller company was a bitter pill to swallow .	- Something unpleasant that needs to be accepted
It is a catch-22 situation - you can't get people without funding, but you can't get funding without the people there in the first place.	- A dilemma or difficult situation from which there is no escape because of mutually conflicting conditions
I will be there on time, come hell or high water .	- No matter what

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The employee training budget came up short last year.	- Fail to achieve a goal; be insufficient
With the economy continuing to do poorly, many investors decided to cut their losses and sell their stocks.	- Abandon an activity that is clearly going to be unprofitable or unsuccessful before you suffer more loss or harm
Their proposals for other developments fell flat .	- Fail completely to produce the intended or expected effect
They felt that the pressures of her work had been the last straw .	- The last in a series of unpleasant events that finally makes you feel that you cannot continue to accept a bad situation
We didn't want to let the opportunity slip through our fingers .	- Fail to take advantage of an opportunity
The investment has helped a lot, but we're not out of the woods yet .	- We're still in trouble
You're playing with fire if you try to evade taxes.	- Do something risky or dangerous
Losing my job was really tough, but I've just been trying to roll with the punches until I get back on my feet.	- Adapt to difficulties by accepting them and carrying on
The company has expanded into many different areas and has probably spread itself too thin .	- Try to do too many different things at the same time (so that you cannot give enough time or attention to any of them)
The alternative was equally bad - she was caught between a rock and a hard place .	- In a very difficult situation and to have to make a hard decision
Three of the original five candidates have now thrown in the towel .	- Abandon a struggle; admit defeat, give up
These small local protests are just the tip of the iceberg .	- A small, noticeable part of a problem (of which the total size is really much greater)
Winning back our trust after stealing is going to be an uphill climb .	- A difficult, tedious process

Conversation questions

- Explain a time when you had to **go back to the drawing board**.
- When was the last time you had to **bite the bullet**?
- Give an example of a **bitter pill to swallow**.
- Have you ever found yourself in a **catch-22** situation?
- What is something you always do **come hell or high water**?
- Talk about a time when you had to **cut your losses**.
- Did any of your projects last year **fall flat**? What happened?
- What's an opportunity you've **let slip through your fingers**?
- Do you ever feel you're **spreading yourself too thin** at the moment? And in the past?
- Have you ever **thrown in the towel**?
- When was the last time you felt something was an **uphill climb**?

Exercise

Fill the gaps with the correct word:

1. Not getting the job was a bitter pill to __.
2. Now they've rejected the whole project we need to go back to the __ board.
3. After last year's disaster, making them sign again is going to be an uphill __.
4. Her ideas were quite good, but the whole proposal just __ flat.
5. I know I'm playing with __ but I'll take the risk.
6. This week's small complaints are just the tip of the __.
7. I'm not going to __ in the towel - I'm not a quitter!
8. Him yelling at me was the last __ - I'm leaving!
9. I promise I'll be there, come __ or high water.
10. This is very complicated, I'm between a __ and a hard place.
11. Sorry, but I can't take on any more responsibilities. I'm spreading myself too __.
12. It was very hard news, but I'll just have to roll with the __.

Solutions:

1. Not getting the job was a bitter pill to swallow.
2. Now they've rejected the whole project we need to go back to the drawing board.
3. After last year's disaster, making them sign again is going to be an uphill climb.
4. Her ideas were quite good, but the whole proposal just fell flat.
5. I know I'm playing with fire but I'll take the risk.
6. This week's small complaints are just the tip of the iceberg.
7. I'm not going to throw in the towel - I'm not a quitter!
8. Him yelling at me was the last straw - I'm leaving!
9. I promise I'll be there, come hell or high water.
10. This is very complicated, I'm between a rock and a hard place.
11. Sorry, but I can't take on any more responsibilities. I'm spreading myself too thin.
12. It was very hard news, but I'll just have to roll with the punches.



12 Success Idioms To Show Off At The Office

If you want to learn idioms and expressions about success, you've **hit the jackpot**! Keep reading and don't forget to do the exercise below to make sure you remember everything.

Success Idioms

Here you have a list with the most common idioms about success. Check them out and [put them in practice](#) at work or with a teacher:

IT has come a long way in the last 20 years.	- Made a lot of progress
Marcy hit the jackpot with her new job -it's basically her dream job, plus a huge salary.	- Have great or unexpected success, especially in making a lot of money quickly; to find exactly what you desired
I might as well kill two birds with one stone and drop off my tax forms while I'm at the mall for the computer part I need.	- Solve two problems with one action or solution
The proposal sounded great, but it didn't live up to our expectations .	- To be as good as expected or hoped for
I thought they were filing for bankruptcy, but they actually made a comeback .	- Achieve a success after retirement or failure
The requirements to get in were very hard, but I still made the cut .	- To be among the options to continue; avoid elimination
Sylvia had passed her exams with flying colours .	- Excel; pass a test or an exam easily or very successfully
No one was sure if he could handle the pressure of making a speech, but he rose to the occasion and did an excellent job.	- Show that you can deal with a difficult situation successfully

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Just when things looked hopeless, my manager came along and saved the day .	- Make a bad situation end successfully
This is the second time I have failed the exam, but as they say - third time lucky . (Also: third time's a charm)	- Two attempts at something have already failed but perhaps the third will be successful
No one believed we would make it, but where there's a will, there's a way .	- If you are determined enough, you can find a way to achieve what you want, even if it is very difficult
Flexible working hours are a win-win situation for employers and employees.	- A result or situation that is good for everyone who is involved

Conversation questions

- Have you ever **hit the jackpot** with anything?
- When was a time you **killed two birds with one stone**?
- Think of the last movie you saw - did it **live up to your expectations**?
- When you were at school, did you use to **pass** all your exams with **flying colors**?
- Talk about a time you **saved the day**.
- Do you think that **where there's a will there's a way**?
- Talk about a recent **win-win situation**.

Exercise

Fill the gaps with the correct word:

1. Happy and engaged employees are a __-win situation for both workers and the company.
2. I know you don't believe it, but trust me - where there's a __, there's a way.
3. You've failed twice, but go for it again! Third time __.
4. Thanks so much for that amazing idea! You've saved the __.
5. We trusted her, but she didn't really rise to the __.
6. Congrats to the whole team! We've passed with __ colors!
7. It seems the company is making a __ when they least expected it.
8. This report won't make the __.
9. I'll give you a ride and kill two birds with one __.
10. We've hit the __ with the new employee!
11. The company has come a long __ in the last 5 years.

Solutions:

1. Happy and engaged employees are a **win-win** situation for both workers and the company.
2. I know you don't believe it, but trust me - where there's a **will**, there's a way.
3. You've failed twice, but go for it again! Third time **lucky**.
4. Thanks so much for that amazing idea! You've saved the **day**.
5. We trusted her, but she didn't really rise to the **occasion**.
6. Congrats to the whole team! We've passed with **flying** colors!
7. It seems the company is making a **comeback** when they least expected it.
8. This report won't make the **cut**.
9. I'll give you a ride and kill two birds with one **stone**.
10. We've hit the **jackpot** with the new employee - she's amazing!
11. The company has come a long **way** in the last 5 years.

Practice all these idioms in conversation

Learn about Talaera's one-on-one trainings